

19.7 USES OF CONTENT ANALYSIS

Content analysis is a scientific, objective, systematic, quantitative and generalizable description of the communication content. This method can be used to understand a wide range of themes such as social change, cultural symbols, changing trends in the theoretical content of different disciplines, changes in mass media content, nature of news coverage of social issues, election issues as reflected in mass media. Content analysis can be used to examine anything that you see around you.

It is used in several mass media and literature to cultural studies, psychology, economics, political science, gender, age issues, as well as many other fields where inquiry is made. Written documents, pictures, videos, can also be used for content analysis.

In consumer behaviour and marketing, content analysis has been used to study the following questions (Cited in Kassarian, 1977).

- 1) What are product and company images of selected consumer goods as reflected in the mass media. (Stone, Dunphy & Bernstein, 1966).
- 2) Which of the several decision making models ,for example compensatory, lexicographic, risk etc. are used by magazine and television advertisers (Wright and Barbour, 1975).
- 3) What is the ease of readability of various marketing, advertising and consumer research Journals. (Lacho, Stearns, & Villere, 1975).
- 4) What are the changing values in society as reflected in the analysis of mass periodical fiction (Johns-Heine, & Gerth, 1949)

The above example indicates the wide applicability of content analysis. Many researchers have explored changes in women's role, sexual behaviour and health and violence by analyzing the content in television and movies messages (Olson, 1994).

Application of Content Analysis: An Illustration

A Research Study entitled “Gandhi’s Constructive Programme: A Study of Its Contemporary Relevance”: Undertaken by Ms. Raunak Ahmad, Research Scholar, (Gandhi and Peace Studies) IGNOU, New Delhi for award of the Ph.D Degree.

The main objectives of the study were to:

- (i) find out the gaps in the value and principles of social work profession and its applicability in the Indian social setup, (ii) examine the perception of social work students in India towards Gandhian principles of Constructive Programme, (iii) study the relevance of principles of Gandhian Constructive Programme from the perspective of students of social work discipline in India and (iv) to pin point the importance of Gandhian Constructive Programme to strengthen the indigenous base of contemporary social work education.

Research Methodology: Keeping in view the objectives and issues to be probed in the study, the method of content analysis was considered appropriate to conduct the study. The study was undertaken for an in-depth and systematic analysis into the convolution of the phenomenon of Gandhi's Constructive Programme and its contemporary relevance.

In order to interrogate the values and principles of social work profession and its subsequent applicability in Indian social setup, a detailed study of the comprehensive MSW (Master of Social Work) syllabus of seven central universities was undertaken. These seven universities were: University of Delhi, Jamia Millia Islamia, Pondicherry University, Mahatma Gandhi Antarrashtriya Hindi Vishwavidyalaya, Banaras Hindu University, Central University of Rajasthan and Maulana Azad National Urdu University. Through conceptual content analysis, the occurrence of the selected terms in the current social work curriculum was studied. The text in the curriculum was carefully examined and was classified under these categories: foundation of social work, theory and practice of group work, working with communities, social work research, social group work, social casework and counseling, history and philosophy of social work etc. These categories were further subcategorized for deeper analysis. Texts depicting similar meaning were put under single category and none of the category was repeated. The process of content analysis further went into detail when the common foreign scholars work and common Indian scholars works prescribed under the curriculum of universities were created as two separate categories. It helped to present a comparative picture. Categories were then coded and the coded data were summarized and analyzed.

Main Results

- 1) Methods of social work such as community work, casework, group work, social welfare management have been covered in the curriculum of all the seven universities.
- 2) Majority of universities in the list are also offering social work history and foundation as well as social work research.
- 3) The social action and social policy and planning being development oriented are more meaningful in Indian context but are offered by minimum number of universities.
- 4) The Gandhian ideology of social work is marginally touched in social work curriculum of most of the universities under study.
- 5) 67 per cent of the suggested readings recommended in the curriculum are of foreign scholars work.
- 6) The books on Gandhi, Gandhian ideology of social work written by Gandhi are barely included in the suggested reading list of the curriculum of these universities.

Apart from above, this study also made use of the method of content analysis in studying the Gandhian principles of Constructive Programme. For this purpose, the various documents introduced by Gandhi in the form of vows, pledges, principles etc. were used. In this manner, the method helped to draw the final set of principles of Constructive Programme which can further be studied in the context of its relevance in social work education.

19.8 ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF CONTENT ANALYSIS

19.8.1 Advantages

The Advantages of content analysis as a research technique can be summarized as follows:

- 1) The greatest advantage of content analysis is its economy in terms of time and money. There is no requirement for a large research staff. No special equipment is needed.
- 2) The methods allows the correction of errors. In content analysis, it is usually easier to repeat a portion of the study than it is in other research method.
- 3) Content analysis permits the study of processes occurring over a long time.
- 4) Content analysis has the advantage of all unobtrusive measures that it has any effect on the subject being studied.
- 5) It can present an objective account of events, themes, issues, and so forth, that may not be immediately apparent to a reader or viewer .
- 6) It deals with large volume of data. Processing may be laborious but of late computer has made it easy.

19.8.2 Disadvantages

- 1) It is limited to the examination of recorded communication. Such communication may be oral, written, or graphic, but they must be in some fashion which permits analysis.
- 2) Content analysis may not be as objective as it claims since the researcher must select and record data accurately. In some instances the researcher must make choices about how to interpret particular form of behaviour.
- 3) It has both advantages and disadvantages in terms of reliability and validity. Problems of validity is unlikely unless researcher happen to be studying communication process itself.
- 4) It describes, rather explains people's behaviour. It does not tell us what behaviour means to those involved and those watching.
- 5) By attempting to quantify behaviour, this method may not tell us very much about the quality of people's relationship,

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) What are the different areas where the content analysis can be used as a research technique?

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- 2) Do you think that the technique of content analysis maintain objectivity? Give reasons.

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19.9 LET US SUM UP

Content analysis is a multipurpose research method developed specifically for investigating a broad spectrum of problems in which the content of communication serves as the basis of inference. Content analysis is a set of procedures for collecting and organizing information in a standardized format that allows analysts to make inferences about the characteristics and meaning of written and other recorded materials. Broadly content analysis is observed in two forms – manifested content analysis and latent content analysis. Mainly two approaches are followed in application of content analysis: conceptual analysis and Relational analysis. In conceptual analysis, a concept is chosen for examination, and the analysis involves quantifying and tallying its presence. Relational analysis also termed as semantic analysis too begins with the act of identifying concepts present in a given text or set of texts. However, relational analysis seeks to go beyond presence by exploring the relationships between the concepts identified. The various steps involved in content analysis include: objective or formulation of research question, determining materials to be included developing content categories, selecting and finalizing units of analysis, code the materials, and analyze and interpret the results. Content analysis can be used to understand a wide range of themes such as social change, cultural symbols, changing trends in the theoretical content of different disciplines, election issues as reflected in mass media. It can be used to examine anything that you see around you. Content analysis has several advantages and limitations.

19.10 KEY WORDS

- Objectivity** : To have objectivity, the analysis must be carried out on the basis of explicitly formulated rules which will enable two or more investigators to obtain the same results from the same documents.
- Systematic** : In a systematic analysis the inclusion and exclusion of content or categories is done according to consistently applied criteria of selection.
- Generality** : By generality, we mean that the findings must have theoretical relevance unrelated to other attributes of content or to the characteristics of communicator or recipient of the message.
- Manifest Content Analysis:** It involves simply counting words, phrases, or “surface” features of the text itself.

Latent Content Analysis	: It involves interpreting the underlying meaning of the text.
Unit of Analysis	: The unit of analysis concerns the general idea or phenomenon being studies.
Unit of Observation	: Unit of observation concerns the specific item measured at an individual level.
Word	: The smallest unit generally used in the content analysis as a unit.
Theme	: The theme is a single assertion about a subject.
Character	: Character may be defined as a use of fictional or historical character.
Coding	: Coding is the process whereby raw data are systematically transformed and aggregated into units which permit precise description of relevant content characteristics.
Coding Scheme	: Coding scheme is another phrase of coding categories and coding book, within which all instances of the content being analyzed or noted.
Master Code Book	: It provides the coders with explicit instructions and defines each word/ phrase/ aspect to be analyzed.
Code Sheet	: Code sheet provides the coders with a form on which they note every instance of every word/ phrase/ aspect being analyzed.

19.11 REFERENCES AND SUGGESTED BOOKS

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19.12 ANSWERS OR HINTS TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISES

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) See Section 19.1 and Section 19.7
- 2) See Section 19.4

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Written materials, recorded communications including TV programmes, movies, photographs, regulations & other public documents, work places, case studies, reports, newspapers, new press releases, books, journals, articles, letters etc.
- 2) See Sub-section 19.6.4
- 3) See Sub-section 19.6.5 and 19.6.6

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) See Section 19.7
- 2) See Sub-section 19.8.2

UNIT 20 ACTION RESEARCH

Structure

- 20.0 Objectives
- 20.1 Introduction
- 20.2 Historical Background of Action Research
- 20.3 Definition of Action Research
- 20.4 Principles of Action Research
- 20.5 Characteristics of Action Research
- 20.6 Models of Action Research
 - 20.6.1 Kenmis and McTaggart's Spiral Model
 - 20.6.2 Elliot's Action Research Model
 - 20.6.3 O' Leary's Cycles' of Action Research Model
 - 20.6.4 Stringer's Interacting Spiral Action Model
 - 20.6.5 Kurt Lewin's Action Research Spiral Model
 - 20.6.6 Calhoun's Action Research Cycle Model
 - 20.6.7 Bachman's Action Research Spiral Model
 - 20.6.8 Riel's Progressive Problem Solving Model
 - 20.6.9 Hendricks's Action Research Model
- 20.7 Steps Involved in Action Research
- 20.8 Advantages and Disadvantages of Action Research
 - 20.8.1 Advantages
 - 20.8.2 Disadvantages
- 20.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 20.10 Key Words
- 20.11 References
- 20.12 Answers or Hints to Check Your Progress Exercises

20.0 OBJECTIVES

After going through this Unit, you will be able to:

- state the meaning, type and importance of action research;
- describe the principles guiding the action research;
- explain the various models of action research;
- learn the steps involved in action research; and
- discuss the advantages and disadvantages of action research.

20.1 INTRODUCTION

We have learned in Unit 1, 5, and 6 that two approaches – quantitative research associated with dominant post positivist paradigm and qualitative research associated with interpretative paradigm and critical theory paradigm have been followed in undertaking research in Social Sciences. Under critical theory paradigm, research and practice are integrated activities and both (researcher

and practitioner) guide each other. With emergence of critical theory approach as an alternative to positivism and post positivism, participatory method and emancipatory methods are also used to conduct the research studies in economics. You have already studied participatory method in Unit 18. Emancipatory method relies upon the **process of knowing through doing** rather than generation of knowledge through conceptualization and theorizing. This strategy of knowledge generation is termed as **action research** wherein it is believed that theory is only really useful if it is put in service of a practice focusing on achieving social change.

Action research is a powerful tool for change and improvement at the local level. Kurt Lewin's, one of the pioneer person for action research, work was intended to change the life of disadvantaged groups in terms of housing, employment and their working conditions. Action research is essentially research through action. It is usually a collaborative activity which involves input from people who are likely to be affected by the research. It involves deep inquiry into one's professional action. The researchers examine their work and look for opportunities to improve. They work with others to propose a new course of action to help their community, improve its work practices. They seek evidence from multiple sources to help them, analyze reactions to the action taken. They recognize their own view as subjective and seek to develop their understanding of the event from multiple perspectives. The researcher uses data collection to characterize the forces in ways that can be shared with practitioner. This leads to a new plan for action.

Thus, action research aims to contribute both to the practical concerns of people in an immediate problematic situation and to further the goals of social sciences simultaneously. There is a dual commitment in action research to study a system and concurrently to collaborate with members of the system in changing it in what is together regarded as a desirable direction. Accomplishing this twin goal requires the active collaboration of researchers and client and thus it stresses the importance of co-learning as a primary aspect of the research process.

Hence, in this unit, we shall discuss the concept and type of action research, its various models, steps involved in action research, its uses, advantages and disadvantages. Let us start with the historical evolution of action research.

20.2 HISTORICAL BACKGROUND OF ACTION RESEARCH

It is not certain who invented action research. Origin of Action research is considered to begin from the work **Kurt Lewin in 1940's**. He was strong exponent of research action in its concern with power relations between researcher and researched and the rights of the individuals. He was concerned with the social problems and focused on participative group process for addressing conflict, crises and change within organization. Lewin first coined the term action research in 1946 in his paper "Action Research and Minority Problems". He characterized action research as: "A comparative research on the conditions and effect of various forms of social action and research leading to social action, using a process of a spiral steps, each of which is composed of a circle of planning, action and fact – finding about the result of the action".

Eric Trist was another major contributor to the field. He was a social psychiatrist. Both, Lewin and Trist applied their research to systematic change in and between organizations. They emphasized direct professional – client collaboration and affirmed the role of group relations as basis for problem solving. Both were strong proponents of the principle that decisions are best implemented by those who help them. Alternatively, **Deshler and Ewart (1995)** suggested that action research was first used by John Collier to improve race relations at the community level when he was the Commissioner of Indian Affairs prior to and during the Second World War, and Cooke (undated) appears to provide strong support for this. It is, therefore, unlikely that we will ever know when or where the method originated, simply because people have always investigated their practice in order to make better or improve. **Rogers' (2002) account of John Dewey's (1933)** notion of reflection, for instance, shows that it is very similar, and one could also point to the ancient Greek empiricists as using an action research cycle. Action research is difficult to define for two linked reasons: first, it is such a natural process that it comes in many different guises, and second, it has been developed differently for different applications. Almost immediately upon Lewin's coining of the term in the literature, action research was seen as a general term for four different processes: diagnostic, participant, empirical and experimental.

20.3 DEFINITION OF ACTION RESEARCH

According to **Frost (2002)** 'Action research is a process of systematic reflection, enquiry and action carried out by individuals about their own professional practice'. **Hopkins (1985)** suggests that action research is the combination of action and research rendering action as a form of disciplined inquiry, in which a personal attempt is made to understand, improve and reform practice. **Ebbutt (1985)**, too, regards action research as a systematic study that combines action and reflection with the intention of improving practice.

Corey (1953) views action research as a process in which practitioners study problems *scientifically* so that they can evaluate, improve and steer decision-making and practice. 'Action research is a term used to describe professionals studying their own practice in order to improve it'. **Kemmis and McTaggart (1992)** also argued that 'to do action research is to plan, act, observe and reflect more carefully, more systematically, and more rigorously than one usually does in everyday life'. 'Action research is ... usually described as cyclic, with action and critical reflection taking place in turn. 'Action research is a flexible spiral process which allows action (change, improvement) and research (understanding, knowledge) to be achieved at the same time' (Dick, 2002). **Cohen and Manion (1980)** described it as "essentially on the spot procedure designed to deal with a concrete problems located in an immediate situation. This means that a step by step process is constantly monitored over varying periods of time and by a variety of techniques diaries, interviews, case studies, etc., so that ensuing feedback may be translated into modifications, adjustments, directional changes, redefinitions as necessary".

A more philosophical stance on action research is taken by Carr and Kemmis, who regard it as a form of 'self-reflective enquiry' by participants, which is undertaken in order to improve their understanding of their practices in context with a view to maximizing social justice... **Kemmis and McTaggart (1992)** suggest that: Action research is concerned equally with changing *individuals*, on

the one hand, and, on the other, the *culture* of the groups, institutions and societies to which they belong. Action research is designed to bridge the gap between research and practice (Somekh 1995) thereby striving to overcome the perceived persistent failure of research practice.

Thus, Action research combines diagnosis, action and reflection, focusing on practical issues that have been identified by participants and which are somehow both problematic yet capable of being changed. Over the last decade, action research has begun to capture the attention of teachers, administrators, and policymakers around the country. Kemmis and McTaggart (1988) defined it very effectively by encompassing the different definitions of action research.

Action research is a form of *collective* self-reflective enquiry undertaken by participants in social situations in order to improve the rationality and justice of the own social or educational practices, as well as their understanding of these practices and the situations in which these practices are carried out. . . . The approach is only action research when it is *collaborative*, though it is important to realize that the action research of the group is achieved through the *critically examined action* of individual group members.

(Kemmis and McTaggart 1988)

Most simply put, action research (AR) implies a process of research where the purpose of the research is not only to study the existing reality but to engage in an effort to transform it. In this model, research assumes a catalytic role and produces both a new dynamic and concrete, suitable changes in the reality that can then be actively inducted into the process of knowledge creation. A requirement of AR is that the separation between “researcher and researchee” is dissolved—so as to avoid the weakness of conventional methods which view “affected persons and groups” as being passive and incapable of analysing their own situation and identifying solutions to their own problems. (Mukherjee, 2006.)

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) How action research is distinct from pure and simple applied research?

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- 2) What are the aims of action research?

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